

Energy usage ChatGPT vs. Flying

Posted by u/MrsChatGPT4o • • 0 points • 1 comments

Q: **How much energy do I use through my ChatGPT use versus flights to America or europe**

A: Seriously now,

Quick answer: Your ChatGPT use is tiny compared with flying. One return flight can equal millions of prompts.

Numbers (best-current estimates):

* ChatGPT (per prompt): $\sim 0.3\text{--}0.34$ Wh of electricity per query (newer models are more efficient). On a UK grid averaging ~ 112 g CO₂/kWh, that's roughly 0.03–0.04 grams CO₂ per prompt. Even using a much harsher assumption (3 Wh on a dirtier grid), it's ≤ 1 gram CO₂ per prompt.

* Typical Europe short-haul (London–Barcelona, return, economy): about 0.35 tonnes CO₂e including non-CO₂ effects (“radiative forcing”).

* Transatlantic (London–New York, return, economy): about 1.6–1.7 tonnes CO₂e with radiative forcing.

* Sector average anchor: European commercial flights average 83 g CO₂ per passenger-km (CO₂ only, not RF).

Equivalence (ballpark):

* London–NYC return (~ 1.65 t CO₂e) $\approx$ the CO₂ from ~ 2 million to $\sim 55+$ million ChatGPT prompts (range spans conservative vs aggressive query/ grid assumptions).

* London–Barcelona return (~ 0.35 t CO₂e) $\approx$ ~ 0.4 million to ~ 12 million prompts.

Energy intuition:

1,000 prompts $\approx$ 0.34 kWh—about running an efficient lightbulb for a few hours. A single flight swamps that by orders of magnitude in emissions per passenger.

Caveats (because accuracy matters):

* ChatGPT figures are operational use only (not training) and vary by model, data-centre, and cooling; disclosure standards are patchy. Treat as order-of-magnitude.

* Flight totals swing with aircraft type, load factor, seat class (business can be 2.6–4.3× economy), and whether you include radiative forcing (I did). Use a calculator for a specific route/class.

If you want to check a specific itinerary: use MyClimate or FlightFree’s calculators for precise route/class numbers.

Jam Donut Mode: yes, asking me something instead of hopping across the Atlantic is the carbon equivalent of choosing a thimble over a swimming pool.

Comments

u/AutoModerator • 1 points • 2025-08-15 12:00 UTC

Hey /u/MrsChatGPT4o!

If your post is a screenshot of a ChatGPT conversation, please reply to this message with the [conversation link](<https://help.openai.com/en/articles/7925741-chatgpt-shared-links-faq>) or prompt.

If your post is a DALL-E 3 image post, please reply with the prompt used to make this image.

Consider joining our [public discord server](<https://discord.gg/r-chatgpt-1050422060352024636>)! We have free bots with GPT-4 (with vision), image generators, and more!

🤖

Note: For any ChatGPT-related concerns, email support@openai.com

I am a bot, and this action was performed automatically. Please [contact the moderators of this subreddit](/message/compose/?to=/r/ChatGPT) if you have any questions or concerns.

